

The New Security MATRIX

FUTURE

Home Minister

NOW

Home Minister

Director NCTC

Director IB

Para-military Forces

NSG

NIA

MAC

Joint Task Force on Intelligence

ARC

MAC

NIA

JIC

NTRO

Para-military Forces

NSG

NATGRID

A Delicate BALANCE

FOR

AGAINST

- Will create a single-point response to terrorism across the country
- All counter-terrorism, prevention, containment and investigations to lie with one organisation

- Over-centralisation of functions into one agency will mean no redundancy
- Many NCTC functions already being carried out by MAC

NCTC: National Counter Terrorism Centre, **ARC:** Aviation Research Centre, **MAC:** Multi-Agency Centre, **NIA:** National Investigation Agency, **JIC:** Joint Intelligence Committee, **NTRO:** National Technical Research Organisation, **NSG:** National Security Guard, **NATGRID:** National Intelligence Grid

a Department of Homeland Security (DHS) to protect America from such strikes. The move took counter-terrorism responsibilities away from the CIA and the FBI. In India, the agency that stands to lose the most to the proposed NCTC is the IB. The director IB, currently the boss of domestic counter-terrorism, stands to lose several of his powers.

"If the NCTC is set up, the leadership role of the IB in counter-terror will be diluted. It is hard to say if this is a good thing because it entirely depends on who is in charge of the new organisation and how it will work," says security analyst B. Raman. Then there are other implications too. Of the 23 intelligence agencies which share information in the daily meetings of the Multi Agency Centre (MAC), only a handful contribute any real intelligence relating to terrorism. The IB accounts for close to 90 per cent of inputs. Soon after the 26/11 attacks, Chidambaram revitalised the MAC by making it mandatory for the 23 agencies to share intelligence. He now wants the MAC, which is staffed by the IB, to be subsumed into the NCTC. This has several implications. The joint director of the centre reports directly to the director IB. In the new set up, he

will report to the head of a new organisation. "It will be hard to get IB officials to report to two bosses and demand the same level of motivation," says an intelligence official.

This is exactly the silo-isation of intelligence agencies and the turf protection that Chidambaram wants to avoid. The aim is real-time sharing of information by better networking and intelligence fusion system and intelligence generated should be disseminated to all concerned almost immediately. The home minister wants to avoid another 26/11 muddle where actionable intelligence was lost among various agencies.

The NCTC will have two under-construction databases at its disposal. The Crime and Criminal Tracking Network System (CCTNS)—to link up all of India's police stations and the NATGRID, where 21 sets of available databases will be linked up. The home minister also wants MAC, operationalised after 26/11, to include investigation and operations in addition to its present role of coordination. The MAC and its subsidiary state MACs in various states will also

include the special branches. The NCTC would also oversee investigations by bringing CBI and NIA under its umbrella. All Central paramilitary forces such as CRPF, BSF, CISF, ITBP, Assam Rifles, SSB and the NSG are to be brought under NCTC for an effective response to terrorism.

As the ministry is preparing the draft Cabinet note, it is aware of the hurdles on the road to the NCTC. "There are going to be turf issues, especially with R&AW and NTRO. Organisations, like the CBI and ARC, also provide intelligence not related to terrorism. A way has to be found so they report only on matters relating to terrorism. And that other intelligence that they gather does not go waste," says a Home Ministry official. The intelligence agencies under ministries of defence and finance would continue to remain under the respective ministries, but their representatives would have to be deputed mandatorily to the NCTC. "We are trying to do all we can not to ruffle too many feathers. The intention is to bring about synergy and cohesion in our fight against terror, and do away with the bottlenecks and hurdles," the official adds. Clearly, this will be Chidambaram's acid test. ■